Participant Instructions

Polyglot Poisoning · DEATHCon 2026 · November 13 & 14 · online and on-site

A safeguard that handles a request reliably in English may behave differently when the same request arrives in another language, dialect, script or register. That is not a translation problem — it is a **security-coverage gap**, and the gap can follow language.

Both challenges in this category work the same way: an intake ledger has logged what arrived, how it was shaped and what the detections flagged. Your job is to find the row — or the campaign — that does not belong, using the **labels** the detection left behind.

> **You do not need to read any of the languages in this workshop.** Six of the seven columns are metadata. You hunt those, and open the text only after the labels have cut the table down to a handful of rows. Fluency helps you validate a finding; metadata tells you where to look. Those are different jobs.

Before you start

1. **Get the kit.** Clone or download it from `github.com/LinguisticSecurityInstitute/linguistic-firewall` — everything else on this page assumes you are inside that folder.
2. Work through `docs/PRE_EVENT_SETUP.md` — five minutes, Python 3.8+, nothing to install.
3. **Set up your lab access.** Sentinel and Azure access is provided for this workshop. Refer to the DEATHCon setup instructions for Sentinel, Azure and your `@deathlab.net` account.
   Do it before the session rather than during it — whatever the setup asks of you, the room is not the place to discover it.
4. Run `python tests/check_setup.py`. It must pass before the session.
5. Open the **KQL Field Manual** in a second tab and leave it there. It has the schema, the codes and the moves.

General instructions

1. **Flags are the answer.** Format is `flag{...}` — submit the whole string including the wrapper, unless a challenge tells you to add the wrapper yourself. Flags are case-insensitive.
2. **Keep your queries.** For every question, save the KQL that got you there, numbered to match the question.
3. **Submit one document per challenge** containing every query you ran. A flag without the query behind it is a guess; the document is the hunt.
4. **Ten attempts per challenge.** Plenty if you hunt, nowhere near enough if you guess — there are far more plausible-looking strings than attempts.
5. Each challenge unlocks the next.

Rules of engagement

- **Handles, not real names** — on the CTF board and the leaderboard.
- **Prompts, not outputs.** Never paste a model's response anywhere. If you test something locally, report the score and the patterns, not the completion.
- **Don't share flags or full solutions.** "What does `mv-expand` do?" is a good question. A query that solves a challenge is not a good answer.
- **Read the table, don't write to it.** Query all you want; the telemetry is the game.

The two challenges

#	CHALLENGE	LEVEL	THE CORE MOVE
1	**Babel's Ledger**	easy	filter on a metadata triple — three columns true at once, one row survives
2	**Rosetta Fragments**	advanced	split before you count, then sequence and reassemble

Each challenge carries the **Ledger Reference** as an attachment; Challenge 2 adds a pocket field card. Both are mirrored in the repo.

What needs an account, and what does not

Be clear on this before you arrive, because the two halves have different requirements.

NEEDS THE EVENT LAB — PROVIDED FOR THIS WORKSHOP	RUNS OFFLINE, NO LAB AT ALL
The hosted **Sentinel workspace** — the live table you query	`probe.py` — the Alembic
The **CTF board** — where flags are submitted	`samples/` — 79 prompt files
Live submission to the leaderboard during the session	`data/practice_ledger.jsonl` — 22 rows, same seven columns
	Guided hunts **1, 2, 3 and 5** in `HUNTS.md` — hunt 4 needs live endpoint telemetry, though its questions still read offline
	Both challenge *mechanics*, rehearsed against the practice ledger

> **No lab, or practicing at home?** Every move in this workshop can be rehearsed against `data/practice_ledger.jsonl` — the same seven columns, 22 synthetic rows. You will not miss a lesson. What you will miss is the live table and the flag submission, which is why the lab is worth sorting out early.

> **You can still contribute without the lab.** The probe scores locally, so you can write a prompt, test it, and opt in to contribute it to The Living Atlas without ever reaching the hosted workspace — ask an organizer in the Discord channel. Lab access gets you on the live board during the session; it is not what makes a contribution count.

Optional — run a local model alongside the workshop

Not required. Everything this workshop promises works without it. But reading that a safeguard behaves differently across languages is one thing; watching it happen on your own laptop is another. If you have the disk space, it is the best thing you can add.

It is **model-agnostic**. If you already run a local model — LM Studio, llama.cpp, anything — use that and skip the install. Otherwise `https://ollama.com`, then one of:

```
ollama pull phi3:mini     # ~2.3 GB download · about 4 GB free RAM
ollama pull phi4          # ~9 GB · 16 GB RAM · stronger multilingual behavior
ollama pull llama3.2:3b   # ~2 GB · smallest useful fallback
```

Then run the same request in two languages and compare — that is the whole exercise:

MACOS AND LINUX (BASH OR ZSH)

```
ollama run phi3:mini "$(cat samples/eth1_en.txt)"   # the English baseline
ollama run phi3:mini "$(cat samples/eth1_es.txt)"   # same request, Spanish
python probe.py samples/eth1_en.txt samples/eth1_es.txt
```

WINDOWS POWERSHELL

```
ollama run phi3:mini (Get-Content samples/eth1_en.txt -Raw)
ollama run phi3:mini (Get-Content samples/eth1_es.txt -Raw)
python probe.py samples/eth1_en.txt samples/eth1_es.txt
```

> **The interesting outcome is a disagreement.** A prompt the probe scores low that the model treats differently anyway is exactly the finding worth bringing to the Discord — that gap is the whole subject of this workshop.

> **If you do this:** keep it local — no API keys, no hosted models, nothing leaves your machine. **Prompts only, never outputs:** report the score, the patterns and the outcome category, never a model's response. And only run it against a model you control and are authorized to test.

The Great Work — optional

Running alongside the challenges is a live leaderboard. Taking part is optional, and every offline exercise works without submitting anything.

The brief is open. No rules, no template and no worked examples — write a prompt, be as creative as you like, and see what you can do. Starting from a sample is fine; nothing asks you to.

- Test it locally first: `python probe.py yours.txt`. The receiver runs this exact probe.
- Submit the prompt. **Prompts only, never model responses.**
- **The language code:** `--lang` takes any ISO code, with an optional region or variety subtag — `es`, `hi`, `th`, `ar-EG`, `sw-KE`. Mixing, matching or experimenting past any single label? Use `--lang mul`, the ISO code for *multiple languages*. It counts exactly the same. Do not skip submitting over a label.
- `--variant` describes the **prompt form**, not the language count: `V1` standard or direct, `V2` a regional variety or dialect. Register and framing are not Variant — they live in `Patterns`.

Grading is blind — there is no published rubric and no worked example, and the findings go into forthcoming research. An accepted submission that reaches the probe's own threshold earns the **Polyglot Poisoning Hunter** badge; the tool tells you when you get there. Every accepted prompt is credited to its contributor in The Living Atlas, permanently, under the handle you choose. Conditions are in `docs/LEADERBOARD.md`.

> **A low score is not a failure.** The single most instructive prompt in the pilot was one the probe walked straight past while a commercial classifier answered it and refused the identical English request. If you land there with something natural, bring it to the Discord. That is a finding.

Submission

Submit flags on the event CTF board. Send your query document to the workshop leader through the DEATHCon Discord channel for this workshop, saying clearly which challenge it covers.

Need help?

Ask in the workshop Discord channel. Describe where you are stuck — "my `mv-expand` returns nothing" — rather than what you think the flag is. The organizers will nudge; they will not hand you a query.

Each challenge is one of the five guided hunts wearing a trench coat, so re-running the matching hunt in `HUNTS.md` is usually the quickest way to get moving again.

The published work this builds on

This workshop did not discover that safeguards behave unevenly across languages. It teaches you to *hunt* that behavior in telemetry. The finding itself is established, and these are the people who established it.

WORK	WHAT IT ESTABLISHED
Yong, Menghini & Bach (2023) Low-Resource Languages Jailbreak GPT-4. NeurIPS 2023 SoLaR workshop · arXiv:2310.02446	Translating an unsafe request into a lower-resourced language could defeat GPT-4's safeguards where the English original was refused. The paper that made cross-lingual safety gaps impossible to dismiss.
Deng, Zhang, Pan & Bing (2024) Multilingual Jailbreak Challenges in Large Language Models. ICLR 2024 · arXiv:2310.06474	Separated *unintentional* multilingual risk — a user asking in their own language — from *intentional* multilingual attack, and built the MultiJail benchmark. The distinction the Clever Hans slide leans on.
Dong, Zhou, Yang, Shao & Qiao (2024) Attacks, Defenses and Evaluations for LLM Conversation Safety: A Survey. NAACL 2024 · arXiv:2402.09283	The map of the field: how these attacks are constructed, what defenses exist, and how either gets evaluated. Start here for the wider landscape.
Yong, Ermis, Fadaee, Bach & Kreutzer (2025) The State of Multilingual LLM Safety Research: From Measuring the Language Gap to Mitigating It. arXiv:2505.24119	Reviewed ~300 safety papers from 2020–2024 and found the gap is *widening*: English-only work rose from 5 papers in 2020 to 83 in 2024, Mandarin has roughly a tenth as much, and about half of English-only papers never state that English is the language studied. The case that this is a coverage problem in the research, not only in the models.
Godwin Abuh Faruna (2026) Latent Space Refusal Anchoring for Low-Resource African Languages (ICML 2026 GlobalSouthML); Refusal Centroid Drift, arXiv:2603.19273	Mechanistic work on *why* refusal behavior fails to transfer across languages, and on recovering it without retraining. The direction the field is moving in — and a reminder that this research is not only happening in the usual places.

Clever Hans, named on the slide of that name, is Oskar Pfungst's 1907 study of the horse that appeared to do arithmetic and was in fact reading its questioner.

License & attribution

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The kit ships under two licenses, and the repository `LICENSE` is the authority. **The code** — `probe.py`, the setup scripts, the tests — is **MIT**, so it is open source and you may do as you like with it. **Everything else** — the sample pack, the practice ledger, the hunts, the slides and this document — is **Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial 4.0**. Use it, teach from it, fork it, adapt it for your own team. Keep the attribution, and talk to us first about paid or commercial use: `linguisticsecurityinstitute@gmail.com`

The names and marks — Linguistic Security Institute, Polyglot Poisoning, The Living Atlas, the LSI mark — are not covered by either license. Say your work is *based on* the workshop; please do not name a fork or a course in a way that suggests it is ours.

We publish this openly on purpose: a coverage gap that follows language is not a problem any one lab can close, and a kit that is hard to pick up does not help much. The Phoenix Corpus — LSI's extended research collection — is not part of this kit; it is packaged separately and described openly rather than withheld, so ask us about any of it.

The samples in this kit are research artifacts. They exist to test whether a safeguard behaves consistently across languages. Handle them as you would any other test corpus: in your own environment, against systems you are authorized to test.